Safety and Retraction: eps2-proposed thesis (tested in ARA); bridge principle argued, not mechanically derived

Abstract

Disclosure: eps2-proposed thesis (tested in ARA); bridge principle argued, not mechanically derived. That, for the same earlier might-assertion and fixed context of use, an obligation on its speaker to retract at a later assessment context occurs if and only if the original belief fails worldly-information safety as evaluated at that later context. The sufficiency direction treats safety failure as enough for the obligation, while the necessity direction requires the separate assumption that no obligation arises when safety is preserved. The target is the obligation to retract that same assertion, not whether the speaker actually retracts, whether retraction is permissible, or whether another person rejects the assertion.

The exact disclosure is: eps2-proposed thesis (tested in ARA); bridge principle argued, not mechanically derived. Later, assessment-relative failure of the original belief's worldly-information safety counts as a defect warranting the original speaker's disavowal of that assertion through retraction. This bridge is not supplied by the cited literature and that the proposed biconditional depends on a further exhaustiveness assumption for its converse. Each direction requires separate support: a sufficient trigger for an obligation does not by itself establish that the trigger is necessary.

Beddor and Goldstein formulate information-sensitive safety as a condition on knowledge (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 5–15). MacFarlane states a sufficient condition for required retraction based on whether an assertion is true as used at its original context and assessed later (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). Hawke examines a safety variant that drops a truth condition and presents countermodels to specified knowledge inferences (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30). Rudin reports a divergence between judgments that a might-claim is false and willingness to reject it (Rudin 2024, PDF pp. 7–9). These discussions do not establish the proposed safety-to-obligation bridge or its converse. Safety failure must not be treated as equivalent to falsity, that rejection must not be treated as retraction, and that the sufficiency of a stated retraction norm must not be reversed to infer necessity. The iff is defended only conditionally: if the proposed bridge and the separate exhaustiveness assumption are accepted, the target follows for the fixed assertion and use context under consideration.

Methodology

Disclosure: eps2-proposed thesis (tested in ARA); bridge principle argued, not mechanically derived. The exact disclosure is: eps2-proposed thesis (tested in ARA); bridge principle argued, not mechanically derived. The test keeps the original might-assertion and its context of use fixed while

varying the later context of assessment. Its outcome is specifically an obligation on the original speaker to retract that same assertion, not whether the speaker actually retracts it or another person rejects it.

That, for this fixed assertion and use context, an obligation to retract at a later assessment occurs if and only if the original belief fails worldly-information safety as evaluated there. The two directions require distinct tests: failure of safety must suffice for the obligation, and safety failure must also be necessary for it. The latter direction requires an exhaustiveness assumption: within the proposed norm, no independent ground imposes the relevant obligation while safety is preserved. Neither direction follows merely from describing safety as relevant to knowledge.

Beddor and Goldstein formulate information-sensitive safety as a condition on knowledge (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 5–15). They describe worldly information as relevant to knowing epistemic-modal propositions (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 4–15). MacFarlane states a sufficient condition for required retraction based on whether an assertion is untrue as used at its original context and assessed later (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). MacFarlane says he does not adopt the rejection approach, because retraction is clearer, and regards the retraction norm as sufficient to distinguish relativism from contextualism (MacFarlane 2014, PDF p. 125) (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). Hawke examines a safety variant that drops a truth condition and presents countermodels to specified knowledge inferences (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30). Rudin reports a divergence between judgments that a might-claim is false and willingness to reject it (Rudin 2024, PDF pp. 7–9).

These source discussions concern distinct matters: a knowledge condition, truth at assessment, rejection, and an obligation to retract. The proposed bridge from assessment-relative safety failure to a retraction obligation is not established by transferring a knowledge condition to the normative status of an assertion. Hawke’s knowledge-inference results do not establish a retraction norm, and that MacFarlane’s truth-based sufficient condition is not the proposed safety-based biconditional. Rejection by another speaker, as discussed by Rudin, is not by itself evidence of the original speaker’s retrospective obligation. Knowledge loss, falsity, belief loss, actual retraction, and rejection must therefore not be treated as interchangeable with that obligation without a separate argument.

The dossier’s verdict applies only to the stated 2018–2026-10-29 bounded search and inspected texts: support for the exact claim was not located there. This verdict does not certify novelty, truth, or an open problem. The proposed biconditional is defended only conditionally, if both the safety-to-obligation bridge and the separate exhaustiveness assumption are accepted. Fixing the earlier might-assertion and its context of use isolates the question of whether its original speaker is obligated to retract that assertion at a later assessment.

Safety, worldly information, and the retraction norm

Beddor and Goldstein formulate information-sensitive safety as a condition on knowledge: a belief amounts to knowledge only if it satisfies the specified safety condition across nearby worlds where the belief is held (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 5–15). They describe worldly information as a

body of information determined by each possible world and relevant to knowing epistemic-modal claims (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 4–15). These are claims about knowledge and the information relevant to it.

MacFarlane states a sufficient condition for required retraction: an assertion is required to be retracted when it is not true as used at its original context and assessed later (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). He distinguishes this retraction obligation from the rule governing whether an assertion may be made (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). MacFarlane says he does not adopt the rejection approach, because retraction is clearer, and regards the retraction norm as sufficient to distinguish relativism from contextualism (MacFarlane 2014, PDF p. 125) (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123).

That, for the same earlier might-assertion and fixed use context, obligatory retraction at a later assessment occurs if and only if the original belief fails worldly-information safety as evaluated there. The target is the original speaker's obligation to retract that same assertion; it is not actual retraction, permissibility, or another speaker's rejection. That, under the proposal's separate exhaustiveness assumption, safety preservation rules out an obligation to retract.

These source discussions distinguish the safety condition, truth at assessment, and the normative status of retraction, but do not establish the proposed biconditional. A condition on knowledge cannot be transferred to an obligation governing an assertion without a further principle connecting them. MacFarlane's truth-based sufficient trigger does not establish a safety-based trigger, much less its converse. The knowledge condition and the retraction norm must therefore remain distinct in assessing the proposal.

The bridge from safety failure to retraction obligation is proposed, not mechanically derived from these sources. The biconditional holds conditionally: if the bridge and the separate exhaustiveness assumption are accepted, the proposal applies to the fixed assertion and use context at the later assessment.

The proposed bridge and the sufficient direction

That, for a fixed earlier might-assertion and context of use, later-assessed failure of the original belief's worldly-information safety counts as a defect warranting an obligation on the original speaker to retract that same assertion. The sufficiency direction is a proposed normative bridge: the later safety failure must count, within the proposed norm, as a defect warranting disavowal of the original assertoric commitment. The claimed outcome is an obligation to retract, not an actual retraction, permission to retract, or a different speaker's rejection of the claim.

The bridge's terms must remain distinct. Safety failure is the specified condition evaluated at the later assessment; falsity at that assessment is not built into the proposed trigger. The proposal does not claim that a belief's failure of safety entails that the assertion was false. Its claim is limited to the connection it proposes between the specified safety failure and the specified obligation, rather than a general principle about what follows from every loss of safety.

Hawke examines a safety variant that drops a truth condition and gives countermodels to specified knowledge inferences (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30). Those results do not establish an obligation to retract. Treating safety as if it already included a truth condition would not supply the proposed bridge; the two notions must remain distinct in assessing the claim.

MacFarlane states a rule requiring retraction when an assertion is not true as used at its original context and assessed from the later context (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). This truth-based rule provides an attributed comparison, not the proposed inference from safety failure to retraction obligation. The comparison identifies the relevant two-context structure—original use and later assessment—while leaving the proposed safety-based trigger to be argued separately.

This paper reasons that the sufficiency direction is conditional on accepting the bridge principle: if later-assessed failure of the original belief's worldly-information safety counts as a defect warranting disavowal of that original commitment, then the proposal requires its speaker to retract the same assertion. The bridge is not mechanically derived from a condition on knowledge, because the proposed conclusion concerns an assertion obligation. The sufficiency claim does not settle whether the belief remains knowledge, whether it is false, or whether another person may reject it; those are distinct questions from the proposed retraction obligation. Fixing the assertion, use context, later assessment, and relevant outcome prevents the sufficient direction from being mistaken for a claim about actual retraction or another speaker's response.

The proposed trigger must be read at the specified later assessment: the norm concerns whether the original belief fails worldly-information safety as evaluated there, not whether it failed safety at the time of assertion. Holding the use context fixed keeps the target constant while assessment changes. That, for the same assertion and fixed use context, later-assessed safety failure warrants an obligation on the original speaker to retract that assertion. The proposal's trigger and outcome are thus linked by a normative rule, rather than by an identity between a belief condition and an assertion obligation.

Hawke examines a safety variant that removes a truth condition and gives countermodels to specified knowledge inferences (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30). This discussion keeps safety and truth distinct but does not itself state a retraction norm. The proposed bridge must therefore be assessed as its own normative commitment: accepting that the later safety failure warrants disavowal is what connects the specified condition to the obligation. The bridge does not require adding falsity as a second trigger. The sufficiency claim is only that, if the specified safety failure obtains and the bridge is accepted, the obligation follows; it does not claim that safety failure makes the earlier assertion false.

MacFarlane states a Retraction Rule requiring retraction when an assertion is not true as used at its original context and assessed later (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). His rule provides a comparison for the structure of the case: an earlier assertion is assessed from a later context. Its truth-based condition cannot simply be replaced by safety failure without the proposed bridge. The cited rule does not establish that safety failure is sufficient for an obligation, because the conditions named by the two rules differ. The analogy therefore clarifies the proposal's two-context structure, while leaving its safety-to-obligation connection as a premise to be defended.

The conclusion remains conditional on accepting that connection. No conclusion about the belief's knowledge status, the assertion's truth, or an actual retraction is needed for this sufficient direction. Only that, under the proposed norm and with the same assertion and use context fixed, later-assessed safety failure brings an obligation to retract that assertion.

Necessity, exhaustiveness, and objections

That, for the same earlier might-assertion and fixed use context, obligatory retraction at a later assessment context occurs if and only if the original belief fails worldly-information safety as evaluated there. The necessity direction is a separate commitment: when the belief remains safe under the specified assessment-relative criterion, the proposed norm imposes no obligation to retract. This direction does not follow merely from a claim that safety failure is sufficient for an obligation. A sufficient trigger need not be the only trigger: even if safety failure entails an obligation, an independent ground could also impose one while safety is preserved, leaving the converse unsettled.

The converse therefore depends on an exhaustiveness assumption. The restricted norm is exhaustive: no independent ground imposes an obligation to retract the same assertion while the original belief remains safe by the specified criterion. The assumption is needed to support the claim that safety preservation rules out an obligation: without it, the possibility of an independent ground remains open. The assumption is not itself supplied by the safety condition, which concerns the original belief, or by the proposal's sufficiency direction, which connects safety failure to an obligation.

This paper objects that a speaker might have some other reason to retract while safety is preserved. This paper objects that the necessity claim, not the sufficiency claim, is challenged by a case in which an independent ground imposes the relevant obligation despite safety preservation. The objection shows why safety preservation alone does not establish the no-obligation result. If an independent ground can impose the obligation within the target scope, the biconditional is not established by the safety criterion alone.

MacFarlane states that there is nothing inherently wrong with retracting an assertion one still thinks true, including when one does not want others to rely on one's word or does not want to take on the obligation of defending the assertion (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). This discussion makes it important to keep permissibility distinct from obligation. The fact that a speaker may retract an assertion despite still thinking it true does not, by itself, show that the speaker is required to retract it. The discussion therefore does not itself refute the narrower proposal about obligatory retraction; rather, it leaves the exhaustiveness assumption to be defended for that restricted norm.

This paper replies that the proposed target is not a claim about every permissible retraction or every possible reason to retract. The claim concerns whether, for the same earlier might-assertion and fixed use context, the original speaker has an obligation to retract at the later assessment. The converse is defensible only if the relevant norm is restricted so that safety failure exhausts the grounds for that obligation. If that assumption is accepted, safety preservation excludes an obligation under the proposed norm; absent the assumption, that conclusion remains unsupported.

Rudin reports a divergence between judgments that a might-claim is false and willingness to reject it (Rudin 2024, PDF pp. 7–9). An assessor's willingness to reject an assertion is not, by itself, evidence that its original speaker has a retrospective obligation to retract it. Rejection and retraction obligation are distinct outcomes, and that the reported divergence does not establish either direction of the proposed safety-to-obligation biconditional. It cannot substitute for the exhaustiveness assumption: willingness to reject does not show that safety preservation creates, or fails to create, an obligation on the original speaker.

The two directions must therefore remain separately stated. The sufficiency direction requires accepting the proposed bridge from a later-assessed safety failure to an obligation on the original speaker to retract that same assertion. The necessity direction additionally requires the exhaustiveness assumption that no independent ground imposes that obligation when safety is preserved. Neither the cited permission to retract nor reported willingness to reject supplies that assumption. The biconditional only conditionally, with the original assertion and use context fixed, and with the outcome limited to an obligation to retract.

Scope, comparison, and conclusion

Beddor and Goldstein formulate information-sensitive safety as a condition on knowledge (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 5–15) and describe worldly information as relevant to knowing epistemic-modal claims (Beddor & Goldstein 2021, PDF pp. 4–15). Hawke tests a safety variant without a truth condition and supplies countermodels to specified knowledge inferences (Hawke 2024, PDF pp. 29–30). MacFarlane states a truth-at-assessment condition for required retraction and allows that one may retract an assertion one still thinks true (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). MacFarlane says he does not adopt the rejection approach, because retraction is clearer, and regards the retraction norm as sufficient to distinguish relativism from contextualism (MacFarlane 2014, PDF p. 125) (MacFarlane 2014, PDF pp. 122–123). Rudin reports a divergence between judgments that a might-claim is false and willingness to reject it (Rudin 2024, PDF pp. 7–9).

These discussions address distinct matters—knowledge and safety, truth at assessment, retraction obligation, and rejection—and do not establish the proposed safety-to-obligation biconditional. Neither a knowledge condition nor a truth-based retraction rule supplies the proposed safety-based bridge, and that permission to reject is not itself an obligation to retract. The cited distinction between rejection and retraction also prevents treating another speaker's rejection as the original speaker's retrospective obligation.

The dossier's verdict is limited to its stated 2018–2026-10-29 bounded search and inspected texts: it records that support for the exact claim was not located there, not that the claim is novel or true. That, for the same earlier might-assertion and fixed use context, obligatory retraction at a later assessment occurs if and only if the original belief fails worldly-information safety as evaluated there. That, under the proposal's separate exhaustiveness assumption, safety preservation rules out an obligation to retract. The claim concerns an obligation on the original speaker to retract that same assertion—not actual retraction, permission to retract, or another speaker's rejection. The iff is defended

conditionally: its sufficiency direction depends on the proposed bridge from later-assessed safety failure to obligation, while its necessity direction additionally depends on the separate exhaustiveness assumption that no independent ground imposes the obligation when safety is preserved. The comparison does not independently establish the conclusion; it stands or falls with those proposed commitments.

Status and method

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